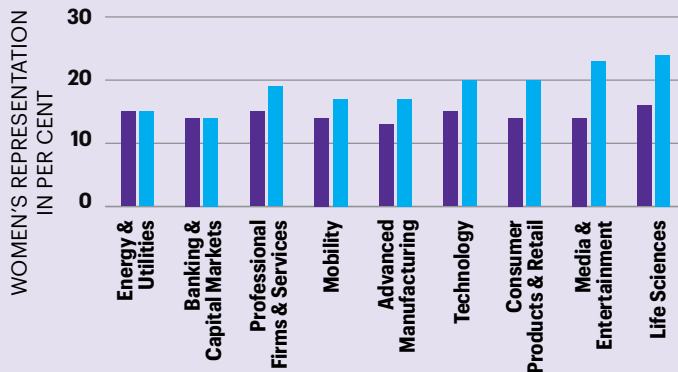


It's not Linear

► There is a significant divergence in gender diversity on boards across industries

► Sectors like Energy & Utilities and Banking & Capital Markets have stagnated

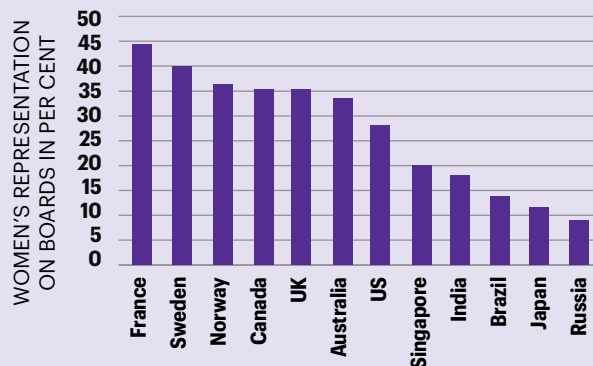


● 2017 ● 2022 SOURCE EY REPORT

Global Scenario

► Compared to countries like the US, women's representation on boards is low in India

► Countries like France, Sweden and Norway have the best women's representation on boards



SOURCE EY REPORT

9 THE NUMBER OF FIFTY 500 COMPANIES THAT HAVE 50 PER CENT WOMEN'S REPRESENTATION, PER PRIMEINFOBASE

Sumit Agrawal, Founder of Regstreet Law Advisors, points out that the mandatory provisions of the Companies Act and Sebi Regulations are catalysts for change in the boardroom, much like the evolution of family laws regarding women's succession and property rights with help from the Supreme Court. "Perhaps, it is time to extend the mandate to all listed companies, moving beyond the Top 1,000, and enforce it rigorously against those who don't comply," says the former Sebi officer.

While the Sebi rule has ushered in quantitative change, experts agree that there is only so much the law can fix where intent is lacking. Again, the Finance Minister had minced no words last September when she said it was ultimately up to the corporates to open up their boardrooms. "The industry will have to take the lead. The government cannot do any more nudging. It cannot be breathing down on behalf of 50 per cent of the population. The pressure, reasoning, and building of a greater sense of conscious decision-making have to come from society to push this agenda," she had said.

With that, the ball is now firmly in the court of India Inc.'s boardrooms to not just comply in letter, but also be more welcoming in spirit. Duggal is hopeful: "The rule is only 10 years old. Give it another 10 years and we won't even have to talk about the gender composition of boards. There may even be boards with women chairs and a majority of women directors."

Amen to that. **BT**

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